

From the start of his administration, Lincoln had to balance military and political demands. Abolitionists wanted immediate emancipation, but he knew he had to hold the loyalty of the border states of Maryland, Kentucky, and Missouri. Only in the fall of 1862, after victory at Antietam, did he feel ready to shift the purpose of the war from restoring the Union to ending slavery. On January 1, 1863, he issued the Emancipation Proclamation, freeing all slaves in areas that were in rebellion against the United States.

In 1864, Lincoln chose General Ulysses S. Grant as overall army commander. In Grant, Lincoln had found a man who would lead the Union to victory, although the horrific casualties from the campaign against the Confederacy's General Robert E. Lee threatened his reelection. General William T. Sherman's capture of Atlanta in September helped save the president, who won the election decisively. Lincoln, however, never lived to see the nation reunited. On Good Friday, April 14, 1865, he was fatally shot at Ford's Theatre in Washington by a Confederate sympathizer.

It fell to Lincoln's successors to lead America through the years of Reconstruction. His second inaugural address stated Lincoln's vision for reconciliation—"with malice toward none; with charity for all; with firmness in the right, as God gives us to see the right ... to bind up the nation's wounds ..."